

Community-Based Grouping Structures

Creating Inclusive, Dynamic Learning Communities

This handout introduces flexible, equitable ways to organize students into learning communities throughout the school day and year — focused on connection, purpose, and growth rather than ability.

Why Community-Based Grouping?

- Encourages collaboration across grade levels and classrooms
 - Builds empathy and school-wide relationships
 - Supports student agency and voice
 - Avoids fixed labels and tracking by ability
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Grouping Structures & Descriptions

1. Interest Pods

Definition: Temporary groups formed around shared interests or passions, often during Genius Time or What I Need (WIN) blocks.

- Examples: Storytelling Pod, Math Games Pod, Gardening Pod
- How to form: Student surveys, teacher observation, or classroom discussion
- Frequency: 1–2 times per week
- Groups and topics rotate quarterly or semi-quarterly

2. Project Squads

Definition: Cross-class groups formed to complete a task or solve a problem aligned with current units of study.

- Examples: Eco Week team, Class Newspaper staff, Innovation Challenge group
- How to form: Student choice or blended assignment

- Duration: Projects and groupings change quarterly

3. Rotating Crews

Definition: Small academic groups (e.g., reading or math crews) that change every quarter.

- Examples: Reading Response Crews, Math Practice Teams
- How to form: Mixed and rebalanced intentionally
- Duration: Quarter-based cycles with fresh configurations

4. Leadership Circles

Definition: Long-term, mixed-age or mixed-class teams with evolving leadership responsibilities.

- Examples: Assembly Leaders, Peer Coaches, Wellness Ambassadors
- How to form: Initial placement with ongoing role rotation
- Duration: Year-long group membership; roles change quarterly

5. Co-Teaching Communities

Definition: Collaborative structures that involve multiple teachers sharing responsibility across classrooms.

- Examples: Grade 4/5 Learning Lab, Inquiry Electives
- How to form: Co-planned, flexible scheduling
- Duration: Weekly or term-based blocks

Design Tips

- Ensure diversity in each group (social, linguistic, behavioral, etc.)
 - Give all students roles or responsibilities
 - Use group reflection to evaluate and improve the experience
 - Re-group students regularly — keep it dynamic and engaging
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Sample Rotation Map (Quarterly with Layered Structures)

Grouping Type	Frequency & Structure
Interest Pods	Weekly (WIN/Genius Time); topics & groups rotate quarterly
Project Squads	Each quarter aligns with unit-based project; student input
Rotating Crews	Academic crews (e.g., reading/math); reshuffled every quarter
Leadership Circles	Year-long group; roles within change quarterly
Co-Teaching Groups	Flexible blocks during week; formed by cross-grade planning